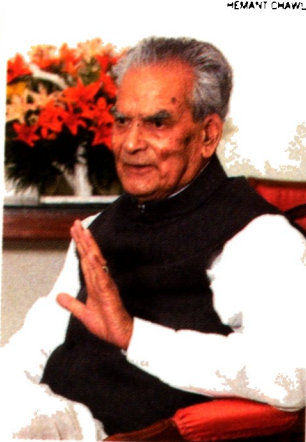




## Stepping Up the Gas

**DELHI** The battle of the bile is at its worst as the race for the country's highest office enters its final lap. After unleashing a scam a day against UPA's presidential candidate Pratibha Patil, the BJP has now launched a website targeting her. "The compilation of the website is by an independent think tank but it's not as if BJP disagrees with the views," said General Secretary Arun Jaitley. Patil retaliated with a four-page statement claiming "an attempt has been made to besmirch my image".

After watching its candidate slowly lose the

war of public perception, the Congress got its act together. "We've done enough fielding, it's now time for some batting," declared Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi, parliamentary affairs minister and a key player of the 'Save Pratibha' campaign. Congress spokesman Abhishek Singhvi and Dasmunshi together turned on the offensive against Bhairon Singh Shekhawat.

The vice-president's past record was scrutinised for blemishes but despite the UPA's best efforts, a campaign to smear his record in police

### BACK TO BACK: Patil (left) and Shekhawat

service failed to take off. Later an anonymous letter circulated by the anti-Shekhawat lobby accused his son-in-law of being involved in land-scams. What is worrying the UPA is that Shekhawat might up the transparency stakes by declaring his assets despite the Election Commission ruling that this is not necessary.

Initially, the Congress toyed with the idea of fielding Patil to the media to counter all the charges against her. However, this ambitious plan was shot down by Union Minister Pranab Mukherjee who argued that this was not a US presidential poll. Privately, Congressmen are wary of any potential bloomers such an interaction may lead to. All her interactions have been limited to press releases.

The BJP says its target is not the presidential polls. Rather, it wants to make Sonia's penchant for "handpicking family loyalists" for both the country's top jobs an issue in E-2009.

by Priya Sahgal

### SIGNPOSTS

**RENAMED:** Cherrapunjee in Meghalaya, famous as the place with the highest rainfall in a calendar year, as **Sohra**, its original name, which was changed to Cherrapunjee by the British.



**WON:** By grandmaster Vishwanathan Anand, the Magistral Ciudad de Leon chess

tournament for a record seventh time, beating Bulgarian grandmaster Veselin Topalov.

**POSTPONED:** The Eleventh Sikh Conclave in Ratia, Haryana, due to the intense stand-off between Sacha Sauda chief **Baba Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh** and the Sikh clergy.

**DIED:** Trainee pilots **Reena Salve**, 25, from Mumbai and **Varsha Gopinath Pillai**, 18, from Thiruvananthapuram when their aircrafts collided in midair in Manila. They had been taking flying lessons for the past five months.

### VIS-A-VIS

**SUSHMA SWARAJ** BJP spokesperson **versus** **B. K. HARI PRASAD** Congress general secretary

“After accepting a foreigner's leadership, the Congress has lost all its moral authority to speak about the freedom struggle.”



“We don't need lessons from a party whose own leader gave an affidavit saying he wasn't part of the freedom struggle.”

SAURABH SINGH

**EPILOGUE:** Even 60 years after Independence, our leaders are squabbling over freedom struggle.